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Robert Glasper

Pianist and composer Robert Glasper has demonstrated one path that the 21st century jazz artist can follow. His melding of R&B, hip hop and jazz has proved highly successful, both critically and in the marketplace. Robert has collaborated with a diverse list of artists including Terence Blanchard, Christian McBride, Kanye West and MeShell Ndegeocello and he currently leads his own piano trio.

Robert was interviewed in Clinton, NY on February 20, 2016 by Greg Thomas, Hamilton class of '85.

MR: Thanks for coming early for this, I'm sure it's going to be a great concert. This is Greg Thomas, class of '85 and he was in the jazz program, he was in the jazz band and he's been here for a few days. He had a great lecture the other day. And Robert Glasper, who you all know. He's got his trio. And I'm going to turn things over to Greg and they're going to just chat for a while and see what they come up with.

GT: Thank you, Monk. And welcome everyone. Thank you for coming to hear this pre-concert chat. How you doing, man?

RG: Good. I had about a five, six hour drive up here.

GT: Oh. From the City?

RG: Yeah, from New York, yeah, from Brooklyn.

GT: Okay. Gotcha. All right. So as you were mentioning off camera, about I guess five months ago there was an event at which I interviewed Mr. Glasper, it was an event sponsored by the National Jazz Museum in Harlem, it was a jazz and R&B discussion. So that was quite cool, and that was in front of an audience of music students at your alma mater, the New School.

RG: Right. Uh huh.

GT: So we went into some kind of musical depth into your history. Here I'd like to direct it for the students here and the students looking. Some of the questions that I ask will be kind of directed towards them and where they're at. All right. So the first question I have for you has to do with the fact that you have a very identifiable voice and style as a band leader, as a performer, as a musician, even as a composer. And I'd like you to talk about the importance of an individual voice. Because you know in the music's history, that was like the thing. That used to be the thing. It's like you've got to have it, your voice.

RG: Totally.

GT: But in music schools when you have, instead of it being on the bandstand and through

cookie cutter, but less — maybe cookie cutter. Maybe less of the individuality. So could you talk about that? Because I think the young people here, they — I think they need to hear about the importance of that.

RG: Yeah, totally. It's — the music in schools is good and bad, you know what I mean? For the most part it's good because if there wasn't music in schools I wouldn't be sitting here, you know, I'd be somewhere in Houston at somebody's church, playing in church, being that cat that's really good in Houston, you know? But I was able to get a full scholarship to go to college, to go up to New York, you know. So that's why, I made it there. I mean Miles Davis went to music school. I mean that's the good thing about school. It gets you where you need to be. You know like some people don't get ahead in life simply because of where they are.

GT: Geographically.

RG: Because of the geographical thing, not because of a talent thing or anything like that. They're just not — you've got to move where the food is or else you're going to be hungry. It's simple. You know so many people have said that, like, "I'm hungry." And I'm like, "you need to go where the food is." You know? And then they don't want to take the sacrifice to do it and it can be hard. But luckily if there's school it takes some of that padding out, it makes it less hard, because of school. And then when you're grown it's like move to New York and you have nothing. Then it's like a little bit harder because now where are you going to live, there's no dormitory and nothing like that. You're grown now so it's a little harder. But for me school was the thing. And, you know, a lot of times with schools, you know you have teachers in the schools, most of the time, that, a lot of them are sometimes failed musicians and you know what I mean? They can teach but they can't teach you how to be yourself. You know what I mean? Some schools have great teachers like that. New School had great teachers like that. They actually have teachers that were on amazing records. Like one of my teachers was Reggie Workman. You know? What else do you need?

GT: John Coltrane.

RG: Right. Charlie Persip, you know? I had cats teaching me that played with Bird. You know what I mean? So that's a different thing. Because they were around all those individual cats and they understand the thing. They're not failed musicians or anything, they're in schools because they want to teach us, give us what they know. Not because that's all they got. And so before music became a music business per se, it was really cool to be yourself and have your own voice. And that's what it was about. Who's different? That's why so many different groups and even individual artists, you're looking in the 60s or 70s and the 80s, there were so many different kinds of artists looking different, sounding

it's literally like three artists you've got to fit in that mold. If you're a black singer and you are a male you've got to fit somewhere in the Chris Brown mold. You know? If you're female you've got to fit in the Beyoncé mold. You know I went to high school with Beyoncé. So that's another individual that I know — I knew her for a long time. You know. But those are certain molds that people say okay, now we need you to be like that because that makes money, versus people taking the time. You know they used to even have a thing called Artist Development in record labels. They would sign somebody and put you through the wringer to help you figure out how to do shows and be on stage, talk to the press, all these things. Now they just sign you and throw you out there. Because they just want to make the quick dollar. Especially now, because record labels are folding and all that. So that don't have no time for no artist development, they don't care. You know? But you know the artists that have the individual voice are the artists that last. And those are the artists that people remember. You know, that's just a real thing.

GT: I think relative to the students, it's really important for them to think about the same things for themselves.

RG: Totally. Yeah. And it's hard to be like, "have your individual voice. Go!" You know. It's like I didn't know I had a voice until people started telling me, "yo man, I was at a rehearsal and the cat was like, 'yo man, gimme that like a Glasper kind of sound.'" You know. I remember when I first heard that. I was in college.

GT: Oh wow. That's cool.

RG: I was actually — was I still in college? I was still in college but I was like a senior in college and there was like some of the cats at the school were having rehearsal for something and somebody told me like, "hey using that Glasper sound." I was like, "wow, really?" That sound? Cool. You know what I mean?

GT: And sometimes somebody else has to actually tell you.

RG: They have to tell you you have a sound because you don't really realize you have a sound until somebody tells you. Then you go, "oh snap. Maybe I do have a sound." You know. But other than that it's like, "oh, I do." You know, and then you start realizing, like I started realizing through the years people were saying, "your compositions are different. They're kind of not like" blah-blah-blah-blah, "they kind of have this feel to it." And I realized what I did is, you know I grew up in church and I never ignored my influences. You know what I mean? So, especially when I'm writing music. When I'm making a composition of my own I never ignore my church influence or my R&B. You know my mom was a singer. I grew up in clubs. You know she didn't let babysitters watch me. She would take me to — I was three years old at the club you know, in the room in the back.

right." [sings] "I'm every woman." You know. So I grew up with all these sounds, and going to rehearsals and everything, and so when I got into jazz and I pretty much got in and really starting like delving into jazz when I was in ninth grade or maybe eighth grade. And when I got into that, you know, what I did was I learned how to play it authentically, because I wanted to sound like Oscar Peterson. I loved Oscar Peterson. My mom used to play him in the house all the time. So I used to try my best to sound like Oscar. I transcribed solos and all these things. So I learned how to play the music authentically. But when it came to writing my own music, I always let my influences influence me. I would give this out. Like this is what I heard you know, and it wouldn't have the normal chord progressions that the average jazz, the normal jazz 2-5-1s they call it, and all that stuff, well it wouldn't be there. It would be something else.

GT: Or A-A-B-A.

RG: A-A-B-A, all that stuff. I wrote from my hip-hop sensibility a lot of the times. You know. I would have a bridge, you know, and it wouldn't be like A-A-B-A, it would be like A-B-C, then a D, then I'd go back to an A. I said, "wait, that's not 32 bars." That's not the normal thing. And so for me I kept that. Because that was who I was. You know what I mean? And when I say that, I don't want people to get it twisted, because sometimes when I say, "let your influences influence you," that doesn't mean everything you play sounds like you're from church. You know what I mean? Because that happens.

GT: That can happen?

RG: Most of the time that happens.

GT: Because that influence is so strong.

RG: It's so strong to where they don't learn to separate it when they're playing a jazz tune you don't have to sound like you're from church. Like church progressions. There are certain things whereas like okay, this is a church cat. Because everything is a church progression, everything is this, everything sounds like you're in praise or worship. And that's not supposed to happen all the time.

GT: Right.

RG: When you're writing your own music, fine. If that's what you're hearing. But when you're in a specific context playing, you know, in a jazz context you have to know when to turn that off and when to turn it on.

GT: That's very interesting. You saying this. Because to me it brings up the issue of genres.

RG: Yup.

GT: So for you, you grew up hearing all of this.

RG: Um hum.

GT: You were exposed to it, you were around it, you ended up playing it. So as I said to you

these different areas, even when I frankly didn't even know the extent of your musical associations with Bilal and this one and Mos Def. I didn't really know that. But I was like this is organic. It wasn't a trick. It wasn't a marketing ploy.

RG: Right.

GT: Sometimes you can hear somebody and it doesn't sound like it really came from their heart.

RG: Right.

GT: You know what I mean?

RG: Yeah, totally.

GT: But with you it was like, I was like, well yeah, I can hear that. The cat can play but he's doing that, he's doing this.

RG: And with all my influences I actually live in those worlds musically.

GT: Simultaneously.

RG: Simultaneously. That's why I can, that's why I feel like I play them well, because I literally was on the road with the masters of their craft. You know what I mean? So like I say I played damn near my whole life in church, so that's one part. But then when I got to New York pretty much as soon as I got to New York, you know, I was in the company of Common and Q-Tip and Mos Def and all those guys, and I started in the Roots. And Questlove used to call me to play with the Roots when I was in college a lot. Then after college I played with them a lot. So now I'm in the hip-hop world and I'm playing that. I'm watching James Poyser and I'm playing all these hip-hop tracks now and learning how to play that vibe. You know, that's the vibe. I get it. Boom-boom-boom.

GT: But each genre has a particular vibe.

RG: Each genre has a particular vibe and it's very egotistical — a lot of jazz musicians think because they have a lot of chops that every other music is easy to play and you can just do it. But that's not the case.

GT: Well T.S. Monk, Thelonious Monk's son, who for years played in R&B, he made it very clear, he's like, you know, you're playing that? Can you keep that time right there? Can you keep it there? Can you keep it there like that?

RG: Right. Bum-bum-be. Yeah. That's T.S. That's my cousin-in-law.

GT: Oh yeah?

RG: Yeah.

GT: Oh okay. Small world.

RG: Small world. So yeah, so basically I went through the training camp of each of those genres of music you know what I mean, basically. In a way.

GT: So then that's how in a way, you're a producer.

GT: Which means that you have the ability to be able to — well let me let you explain. Now you mentioned yourself as a composer, as a player. As a producer, explain how you see your role as a producer.

RG: I mean as a producer, as far as my own stuff or producing other people?

GT: Other people.

RG: Well as a producer the thing a great producer is supposed to do is bring the best out of that person, what they are.

GT: Like great teachers do.

RG: Yeah, exactly. Bring, you know, some producers, when they produce something you hear it and you're like okay so-and-so produced that. I hear it.

GT: Mmm. You could hear the stamp of the producer.

RG: Hear the stamp of the producer. Which is not always bad. You know you hear something Babyface did, you're like, "that's Babyface." You know? Duh. That's Face. You know. You get it. That's R. Kelly. You know? Certain producers have a thing, and some people want that thing. Because that thing sells and that's what — you kind of want people to know that's you, and that's a different kind of producing. But from what I'm doing, I like to bring the best out of that particular artist, so I try to dwell in what they — where they live and figure that out and then go from there.

GT: Quincy does that, right?

RG: Yeah, Quincy does that. Exactly. Exactly. They didn't want Quincy producing Michael [Jackson] because he was a jazz guy. They didn't want him doing "Off the Wall." Michael had to fight for Quincy to do "Off the Wall," because he was the jazz guy. He never really did R&B like that you know. And boom.

GT: History was made.

RG: History was made.

GT: Now tell us about your collaboration with Kendrick Lamar on "To Pimp a Butterfly."

RG: Yeah, Kendrick, first of all a lot of my friends are on that, are producers on that, on all the Kendrick stuff from "Section.80" and "good kid, m.A.A.d. city" and all his records. One in particular, Terrace Martin, a producer, I went to jazz camp with Terrace in high school, when I was 15 years old, and we met each other then. He's in L.A. He's from L.A. and we all met at Loyola in New Orleans, they had like a national high school jazz band thing. We were both in there. So we kept in touch all through the years. And he used to call me up to do Snoop Dogg tours and stuff, because he was Snoop Dog's music director too. I was never around to do them. As soon as I got in college I pretty much went on the road with Christian McBride and Russell Malone and Terence and a few other people.

RG: Terence Blanchard. So I was never really at school very much. Especially my sophomore year on I was gone a lot.

GT: Okay. And it's good to go to a school that —

RG: That allows you to do that. Yeah. I still had to fight. Some of them teachers was wishing they was on the gig.

GT: No, you be in class.

RG: Right. But I'm playing at the Vanguard for a week. But most of the teachers were super cool about that, and the New School was really cool about that. That's the thing. That's what you're there for. You know. So anyway fast forward, I heard "good kid, m.A.A.d city" and it blew me away. And I called Terrace and I was like, "yup, I have to be on the next CD somehow," to be on Kendrick's next album. He's like, "gotcha. We gonna make it happen." I was like, "aye, bet." And so fast forward I'm doing my trio album, "Covered" — I put out last year.

GT: This was your last recording.

RG: My last recording. And I'm in L.A. And that's the thing about going where the food is, because L.A. is one of those places where there's a lot of food. So I did two recording nights there. The first night I go, I'm recording at Studio A. I recorded it live in the studio at Capitol Records. In Studio B was John Mayer recording his record. He walks over, he's like, "hey, Robert." We'd never met in person. He's like, "Robert, what's up?" I go, "hey man, I've never met you" blah-blah-blah. He was like, "after you finish your recording, you want to come over to my studio and jam?" I'm like, "aright." So I finished my recording and I went next door and jammed with John Mayer for two hours. Duo. Just me and him. You know? At the studio on tape.

GT: On tape?

RG: On tape, yeah.

GT: All right.

RG: So I don't know if anybody will come up with anything, but, that happened. It was like that was pretty awesome.

GT: Cool.

RG: The second night, before I walked on to play, Terrace called me, he was like, "yo, I'm at the studio, at Dr. Dre's studio. Can you come here right after you finish your session?" I was like, "aright." So this is the funny part about this whole thing. I go in, I finish my recording session, mind you "Covered" is a trio album but it's not straight ahead jazz. You know we're pretty much doing cover songs and it's not [scats] you know. As soon as I go to the Dr. Dre studio, I walk in, Kendrick's there, I didn't even know what I was going for. Terrace is like, "Kendrick this is Rob" boom-boom-boom-boom. He was like,

"I want you to play on some joints." I was like, "cool." The first song was [scats a swing groove].

GT: Love it. Love it. The irony of that.

RG: The irony of that. I go from a jazz session playing hip-hop to a hip-hop session playing jazz.

GT: Love it. Love it.

RG: And so the first thing, Terrace is like, this first tune I want you to sound like McCoy Tyner. You know? It was a song called "For Free." And Kendrick's like doing a poem over it and we're swinging and like going in. You know what I mean?

GT: Right. Oh yeah.

RG: So I was like this is so random. So then after I did that song Kendrick pulled up a bunch of other songs that they already recorded. And he was like, "hey could you hear anything over this?" He'd be playing and I'd be like, figure it out, record. He's like, "play anything you hear." And I'd just play. He was like, "killing." No pull up so-and-so, pull up so-and-so. I sat there and I recorded eight songs in one sitting, right there, just that night.

GT: Didn't send him the charts.

RG: No charts. No I just played it and I listened to it. Thundercat was there too so some of the songs he wrote he came in and showed me the joint, I learned it and then he would record and I would just like play what I heard, you know? And so there was nine songs on the album. So I came back Grammy week, because we were nominated for Black Radio 2 at that time. And so I came back Grammy week and that's when we did the "Mortal Man" the very last song with the Tupac interview on it. That's when I recorded that. But yeah, I'm on nine joints. It's only credited five songs. Because after I did what I did, you know, months after that they forgot what I played on, you know, hip-hop. That's one of the things with hip-hop you don't get your business right.

GT: Right.

RG: But I'm on there. But anyway it was just an amazing opportunity and it was the irony of, like you say, going from the jazz session playing hip-hop, to the hip-hop session playing jazz.

GT: I love it. Love it.

RG: And it's just full. You know what I mean?

GT: So describe your process. Let's go to your trio, of arranging. I listened to — I purposely did this, I listened to "Covered" and then I went back to your first two joints with the trio so I could hear — and it's identifiable. But with "Covered" that seems like some intricate arrangements and textures. You know, you always set up a groove but then there are surprises in there all over the place. So describe your process of arranging when you're

with your cats. And I also want you to tell us the two cats that you'll be playing with today, how far you all go back.

RG: Oh Damion Reid and Vicente Archer. The trio. I go back with them since 2000. Yeah 2000. Not two thousand and, two thousand. I met Damion in college, the drummer, in college. But the process with them is pretty much — on those other albums, those earlier albums were just original, mostly original songs. And I like to write for those particular musicians in that seat.

GT: That Duke Ellington vibe.

RG: Yeah, exactly. That's why Duke's band is different from any other band. Because he wrote for the cats that were there. You know, he had these people in mind so the whole thing has a sound and a characteristic versus writing just the drum chair, the piano chair, this chair, that chair. You write for a specific person. And you don't write a lot. Because I don't like to write a lot of stuff. I like to let that particular musician give me him. You know what I mean? Like when I write for Vicente or when I write for Derrick Hodge in my experiment band, when I'm writing something or when I hear Derrick doing him I'm like oh my God, he's going to kill this. So I don't want to write, "play specifically this." Sometimes writers can do that and, for me, when I do that with my bands it kind of puts it in a box and it can be bigger than what I'm thinking almost. Because whey they're going to do is going to be better than what I'm going to tell them to do.

GT: So what do you actually write?

RG: It's trust I use. What I write —

GT: I mean for them.

RG: For them, I mean for the most part I'll tell them a skeleton, like, depending on the song, obviously there are some songs I have that in the trio days that specific bass line I would write. But then I would be like get away from it and do you, and let the drummer kind of feel. Like it's in seven, this is kind of the vibe, go for what you hear. You know what I mean? So it's a mixture of that. Some things I'm specific on because I have to be specific because I have a certain thing I'm going for, but even in that I give them room to interpret it a little bit. I don't do specifically every little thing. You know what I mean? And to me that's how you have the best groups, that's when it's a group. Because you're letting each person bring their personality into the music and no other band's going to sound like these exact three people. You know what I mean? Versus you writing something for this or another person. I could go to another band and do the same thing and then it sounds the same because you're doing exactly — you're reading the music and you're doing exactly what I need you to do, but I like to — you give me your feel, you give me your feel [claps] and then it's going to sound like something like no other

that's one thing he was a master at. Miles was the master at finding the right guys. He didn't change. You know? Miles never really changed as far as his playing. He just got the right cats under him because he knew what sound he was going for and he was like, okay, these young guys know the vibe boom-boom-boom-boom we'll try the young vibe and then put my thing on top of it. And that was something.

GT: Did you hear the story about when Miles first got Herbie, Tony, Ron and Wayne together?

RG: Which one?

GT: Yeah right. I think this is the one where they first went to his house. And he was in another room. And they didn't know that he was listening to them from the other room. But he was just checking them out.

RG: Right. Right. Right. Right. Right. That makes sense. Yeah. That totally makes sense.

GT: Yeah. Like a master of masters, teacher of teachers. I mean so many leaders came from Miles.

RG: Um hum. Exactly.

GT: Now I'm going to ask one more question then you all get ready because I'm going to let you all get in here. I want to talk about tradition and continuity of tradition. I did a presentation here on the great writer about blues and jazz, Albert Murray. And one of the things he says in his book *The Hero and the Blues* is that of course tradition is that which continues. That's obvious. But he says if the tradition is not — this is my paraphrase — renewed then the tradition can atrophy. So you actually need change for the tradition to remain alive.

RG: A tradition is change also. You know what I mean? What is a tradition? When you think of a tradition as — that's why people talk to me about that stuff, about you don't even know what you're talking about from the beginning, your question don't even make sense. Why don't you keep more of the tradition? Which tradition? Which era? Which one? The thirties? Because when the forties hit, that was something different. When the fifties hit, that was something different. When the sixties hit, each era looked back on the other era, or looked ahead at the other era like, "what are you doing? That's not the tradition." You know? They all did that. The thirties looked at the forties like what are you doing? The forties looked at the fifties, what are you doing? And like the sixties, what are you doing? That's the tradition. If you're not making the other era mad you're not following the tradition. Your tradition is to piss you off.

GT: Or in the academy they call it paradigm shifts.

RG: Yeah, yeah, yeah, exactly. But that is the tradition. The tradition is to honor the history but not be held back by the history. And you keep it moving. You keep it moving. But

Because that's the only way to keep it alive. Miles said it. If it ain't moving it's dead. Period.

GT: All right. I see a lot of heads shaking out there. So why don't you all get up in this, all right? So if you've got a question or a comment raise your hand and partake. All right. This is Professor Michael "Doc" Woods, Professor of Music here for many years.

RG: Hello, sir. Nice to meet you.

GT: Great composer, bassist.

RG: I'll bet you're a musician.

MW: Your church background I think is just fabulous. Do you see any way in the immediate future on your event horizon where you can kind of revolutionize, particularly in black churches, what the black pastors will let the young musicians do?

RG: I think that's already changing. Granted, they kicked me out of church in '99. Footnote, I got kicked out. But thank God, when I was playing in church in Houston when I got a scholarship to come to New York, my pastor in Houston led this church called Brentwood Baptist Church, and my pastor said, "I'm going to call my boy up in Harlem and you're going to play at his church when you get there." So I had a good job the first week I got to New York. I got to New York, they put me over to the male chorus first of all, I'm 17 or 18 years old over the male chorus, I'm like, "no!" They were horrible, it was really bad. And then a few months after that they put me on the teen choir so it was like yes. So the teen choir was cool. At that point I started getting calls from, like I said, Christian McBride and I started going out of town. And at that point it wasn't cool to go out of town. I mean you've got to be at church. So after a while it was like I had to make a decision, to be here or not. So I said I had to leave. It's now become cool for your music director to be gone, because the pastor can say, "our music director is out with Mary J. Blige this Sunday." You know. And when you get back from tour, all my friends that still play in church tell me that, I've got a bunch of cats that play with everybody and the pastor comes back and, "so our bassist just got back from the road from the Beyoncé tour." So it makes it hard — it gives the church a little popping thing. Who did your piano player play for? You know. So I think now it's become a lot more acceptable. You know what I mean? And you know I think that's just the culture now. You know? You do other stuff and I play at this church. It's almost like giving the church publicity when you're on the road a lot of times. Because the people want to kind of — the people want to go to the church that has the really good music as well. The younger people tend to want to go to the church with good music. Older people want to go to church for the good preacher. So if you have both it's great. The best choir, the best musicians get a lot of the younger people. You know what I mean? So if the word on the street is, you know,

I've played with Maxwell for five years, and in 2009 when he came back with "Pretty Wings" and all that stuff, so I did that tour, from '09 to 2013, and my boy Shedrick Mitchell was on organ on a church gig every Sunday. But he was telling me, that's why I know a lot of these things because he was like he said, "yeah my pastor — I always sang that stuff — it fascinates people." But I thought you were going to ask me if I was going to do a Gospel album. Because I am. I'm going to do a Black Radio Gospel album.

GT: Is this the first time you said it anywhere?

RG: No. I've been saying it for like two years now.

GT: Bobby Jones's going to do it first.

RG: Right. The funny thing is, I played on Bobby Jones' show when I was in eleventh grade. Didn't Bobby Jones get canceled? I think he's off the air now. This is the last year. Yeah, I played with a choir on there when I was in high school. I'll never forget that.

GT: Now by the way, you may have noticed you don't hear yourself in the mic. Just go right ahead.

Question: My name is [sounds like] Johnny Enoch. My question is —

RG: Enoch? I have a song called "Enoch's Meditation."

Question: Yes, and I love it. I really do, I love it. My question is do you, or do you have a staff, are you mentoring any other people who would like to be in the industry or in the music?

RG: I don't have time at the moment. I do have like, you know, if cats come to New York and I'm in New York and I'm doing something I have a few younger cats that they want to come through and hang out and check it out, they can do that periodically here and there. But I haven't done an actual like mentor thing yet, like hard core. Because I'm just all over the place. And I even tried to give lessons for a year and that didn't work out. Because just my schedule was too crazy and I have a 7-year-old son myself. So when I'm not crazy he gets all my — he's here. You know. Yeah, Robbie's here. He gets all my attention and I don't have time for another one. But eventually I want to open up a school of some sort that has teachers that are like-minded like me and use that. Because the tools that I have and a lot of my friends have, musician friends have, is something that can sustain a musician in today's times. You know what I mean? A lot of times colleges put out these like jazz robots. And people say, "well I'm broke" because they don't know any other kind of music. Can't play any other kind of music.

GT: Well it used to be where cats would play a jazz gig or a blues gig or R&B, a bar mitzvah.

RG: Yeah. That was the thing. That was what it is. Blues, all that. All that, you remember? One of my favorite musicians was boogie-woogie playing, Mulgrew [Miller] was, all that, you know, Coltrane walking the bars.

Question: Are we allowed to take photos or not?

Question: Are we allowed to take any photos?

RG: Yeah, yeah, sure. Yeah.

Question: What's the highlight of your career thus far? And is there another "Black Radio" coming or in the works?

RG: The highlight of my career. I would probably say winning my first Grammy and it being an R&B Grammy. You know, for "Black Radio," the original "Black Radio" album. I think that was the highlight pinnacle of my career because that's like winning the NBA championship, you know, if you are a basketball player and you win the championship that's the highlight of being a basketball player. You know. So for me that was one of the big moments. Because it was such a underdog kind of thing. You know what I mean? It was really like we went against the music industry, we went against radio, you know, we went against all the things that are supposed to work. I used — all the music was live. Couldn't get all the people together in one room. And so I actually cancelled — I stopped the record. I didn't even, I was like I can't get everybody together and I was like forget it, let's just go on tour. So we went on tour. And in the middle of my tour my manager just called me and said, "I don't know how it's happened but all these people, all 20 people, their managers called me and they're all available this one week." So and that was the next week. So I canceled my tour from Europe. I canceled the week and I flew to L.A. and that's why there's so many cover songs on "Black Radio" — we did like half of the record is cover songs. Because I didn't have anything written because it was so last minute. You know what I mean? So I did a bunch of covers because I didn't have any songs. And a lot of the songs we did were on the spot. The song we did with Ledisi, we re-did one of my old joints, "F.T.B." because she literally came to the studio at three in the morning and we sat around a table and she was like, "what do you want to play?" You know, and I was like, "I don't know, what do you want to do?" And we threw out some songs na, um, na, not that. I said, "this song?" She said, "okay, cool." We listened to it, wrote lyrics to it, [claps] went in the studio. With King, they were a new group. You know, and My Home-Grown was managing them. And I went to their creative and I had to do my laundry, because I just got back from tour. They had a laundry. So I literally walked into the studio in the living room and I came up with this little idea and I was like, "here's the idea. I'm gonna do my laundry." So I did laundry. And I came back, the song was done. I was like, "great." No this is literally how the album got done. So I always tell people the universe co-produces your album. You know what I mean? I mean I've learned that for a long time. The universe will co-produce your album and when things are not going right it may be for the better, but it's hard to realize that in the moment. But it may take a left turn for something you didn't know. Like the "Ah Yeah" song. "Ah

Because the radio grabbed that song really quick and started playing it on the radio stations. So I started getting all these offers to do things. And thinking about "Ah Yeah," I recorded just the music in L.A., I called up Musiq Soulchild blah-blah-blah this record blah-blah-blah-blah-blah. He's like, "all right. Come to Atlanta, let's record it." So I flew to Atlanta. And I was there for three days. The first day I went in he heard it, listened to it, walked around, was kind of writing to it. Cool. He wrote a first verse. And then he wrote the second verse. He said, "I'm going to record it tomorrow." I was like, "cool." That night I went to a music festival in Atlanta. They had a music festival happening. Foreign Exchange was there. And Phonte asked me to sit in with them that night. He had heard I was in Atlanta. So I went to sit in with Foreign Exchange. I sat in, after I got off the keys, Chrisette Michele was there because she was ending the night. She was like, "what are you doing here?" I was like, "oh I was sitting in with Foreign Exchange but I'm actually recording an album." She's like, "oh word" blah-blah-blah-blah. And I was like, "how long you in town." She was like, "well my flight got canceled, I was going to take a red eye tonight but my flight got canceled because there's a big storm in New York." And I was like, "what you doin' after this?" She was like, "nothing." And I was like, "come down the studio." And that's how she got on the song. Because she couldn't get on the flight. And I saw her and I was like, "hey, you want to come down?" And that became the best part of my biggest song, radio-wise. That's my biggest song.

Question: So is there another "Black Radio" in the works?

RG: Yeah. Not in the works, but definitely, I'm going to do another "Black Radio" or three, and like I said, a "Black Radio" Gospel album.

Question: Do you work with a lot of unknowns?

RG: No. Not at the moment. I presently have a lot of friends that are unknown artists that are dope. I know a lot of great artists that are quote unknown. But I even tell them, from the beginning, people are like, "why don't you have me on." And I'm like, "let me put myself in a position first so that I can bring you all up." And people have to understand that I have to put myself in the position and I have to use people who are already established in order to do that. You know what I mean? So now I'm in a position, I can do that. I can bring some people who no one knows, but now I have clout and people listen to what I think. You know? So if I say this person is dope, a lot of people are going to be like, "they must be dope." You know? But if I woulda did that from the beginning man it wouldn't be me or you. You know we ain't helping each other out. So you know, so eventually I wanna do an album with a bunch of underground artists that no one knows that people should know. I'm definitely going to do that record too you know.

Question: Yeah, so I think that there's been a lot of movement towards infusing jazz and funk

D'Angelo and Erykah Badu, but with people like Flying Lotus and Kendrick Lamar obviously and Chance the Rapper who are doing that a lot. And it's becoming really big. What do you think is the cause of that at this time now in history, being such a big movement that's happening right now?

RG: Well I think there was two waves of it. I think there was one wave in the early or late 90s, the neo-soul movement. I was in New York when that happened. I didn't realize it at the time but it was happening. I got to New York in '97. I met Bilal in '97. We started working with his album. And we were working on his album at Electric Lady Studios, Jimi Hendrix's studio. And Erykah was on the — we were on the top floor, Erykah was on the middle floor and D'Angelo was on the bottom floor. So I literally watched D'Angelo make "Voodoo" a lot. I didn't even know. I was there for that. I was there for comedies like "Water for Chocolate" because Bilal was singing background in that. I didn't even know Common. In '99 I didn't even know who he was. I wasn't into hard core hip-hop. I came from Texas. I knew Scarface. You know? I knew Ghetto Boys. So I was teaching Common piano lessons. I used to go to his house and give him piano lessons. He lived around the corner. Me, Bilal, Erykah and Common live within four blocks of each other in Brooklyn. So Erykah used to come over my crib and play me stuff, ideas, and, "what do you think about this song, 'Orange Moon.'" I'm trying to think. Because I was the jazz guy. I was Bilal's friend who played jazz. And they all was like, "what do you think about this jazz." And Common was like, "I want to learn jazz." You know. So I'd give him piano lessons. So that was all a regular thing for me. And I think it was just like a movement. The neo-soul movement happened and live musicians came back and poetry started popping then in '97.

GT: Spoken word.

RG: Spoken word. And spoken word goes right with jazz and that whole thing. There was all that combined. That scene actually happened a block from my house where I used to live a few years ago, in Brooklyn, at the spot called Brooklyn Moon actually. That's where Saul Williams did his first poem and that's where Erykah used to go.

GT: Now you said there was two waves, so that was one?

RG: That was one wave. And that, and I was a part of that wave with Bilal's band. We were going on tour with Erykah and Common and opening up for those guys, and the Roots and all this stuff. Then neo-soul kind of died down and then, not to toot my own horn, but when "Black Radio" came around I think that started another wave of college kids coming up and doing their own thing. You know? That's why you have groups like The Internet and people from Berklee, even Internet, Hiatus Kaiyote, Snarky, all these other artists coming up doing their thing and getting recognized. We're in a great time right

Grammy, which never happened, an instrumental band has never won and R &B Grammy before, in the history of it. You know what I mean? And so when we won that everybody googled who are you, first of all, you know. But then they listened to it and they were just like oh, and people kind of became open to it. That's why you see all these other bands now coming into those categories and stuff. And it's another wave of music that's all doing that. It's amazing to see.

GT: I would say it's a precursor to the two wave. You've got Digable Planets. You had "Guru," it's a jazz thing, that was early 90s.

RG: Tribe.

[inaudible]

RG: So a lot of those things were the D.J. mixing the jazz in.

GT: Into the instrumental, right.

RG: Yeah. Because the thing I like about my band, especially the experiment band, which is different from most, because a lot of people, I've had smart alecks after me, "that's been done before, what are you doin' different?" Like well we're one band. Like we're one band playing hip-hop, playing jazz, and playing R&B to a very high level. To the point where the jazz cats are like, "y'all the best jazz group we've ever heard." And then hip-hop, the Roots, Amir is like, "y'all play hip-hop the best." You know what I mean? One band getting that kind of credit and playing all those things is different than a D.J. playing the jazz part and mixing in the saxophone. You know. Or scratching. You know. You know. And so that's the difference, and it's the live band aspect and people playing all these different genres themselves and not needing a D.J., "okay, you're the hip-hop part." You know. Now we're mixing jazz and hip-hop. That's been done before. You know what I mean?

GT: So let's give Mr. Glasper a hand.

RG: What time do I start?

GT: 7:30.

RG: I start at 7:30? We can do five more minutes. If it's okay with y'all.

GT: All right next.

Question: I was going to ask who are you listening to most right now. Who are your favorite groups?

RG: Favorite groups?

Question: Yeah favorite groups or artists coming up kind of right now.

RG: I haven't been listening as much these last few months because I've been going to so many projects on my own. And when I do projects on my own I purposely don't listen to a lot of other stuff. Honestly. But I like The Internet. I just kind of got hip to them last

groups, as far as new rising, up-and-coming cats. You know what I mean? I like those people. I like Laura Namulemu. You know Laura Namulemu? She's from London.

GT: I have one or two more questions. For the record, you've covered David Bowie songs, he just passed. Maurice White Earth Wind & Fire just passed. Speak about those two in terms of your thoughts about them in particular.

RG: Oh yeah. I mean Maurice White is you know, they were doing, not hip-hop and jazz, but they were doing funk and soul and jazz.

GT: Gospel and Afro-Brazilian too.

RG: Everything. There's an album "That's the Way of the World."

GT: Yeah. '75.

RG: "That's the Way of the World." That still to this day that has to be one of my favorite interludes of all times.

GT: "Bahia?"

RG: No. It's "Interlude" after oh I forgot the song it's after. But it's a [scats]. Anyway they were ahead of their time for that. That "Interlude" it's literally my favorite interlude ever. It's like 45 seconds and it's so dope. You know. And they way they did it was dope and ahead of their time the way they did it too. They took something and flipped it, they took something, another song of theirs, "Celebration," and flipped it and flipped the tape and made it go backwards. And then Bobby Lyle soloed over it going forward. It was like, "really, that's what you're going to do?" And it was so crazy. And on the same album they have a jazz interlude, I forget what it's called, something jazz. But they just walk in the studio and you hear them giving them a set and they start playing, it's like a blues or something. But then it goes into "The Way of the World." You know what I mean? And that was just normal back then. And I mean I knew that record for a long time because my mom used to play that all the time and my dad used to play it all the time. You know what I mean? So that's one of the things I would hear, and just like that's normal. Jazz, going to this, what's the problem? You know what I mean? David Bowie, you know who reminds me of David Bowie? Bilal. He reminds me of David Bowie a lot. Artistically, Bilal's weird and so is David Bowie, super-weird. And they're very much, they play characters when they sing. It's not about — a lot of singers, every time they sing it's like let me show you how good I sing. I don't care what the song's about, I don't care about selling the song to you, I want you to know I can sing very good. You know. And some singers are about characters and being a character for that song, like it's a part. You know what I mean? And trying to tell a story. Prince is one of those people. You know what I mean? Bilal's one of those. David Bowie's one of those to me. David Bowie could really sing. But that wasn't his point. You would catch it. Because he's really dope. But that

Oddity," it's a very obscure album. But I recorded the song on there called "Letter to Hermione" for "Black Radio" 1 back in 2011. And when I heard it it just reminded me of Bilal. And at that point I didn't have a song I wanted Bilal to sing yet. And I was just listening to that album, "Space Oddity," and then that song came on and I was like wow. It was like oh my God. And the way he sings it, if you haven't heard the original, listen to the original. It's just David Bowie and guitar and maybe two guitar players. And it's just so sincere and so honest. You know? And I think that's what's missing too, the honesty in the music, which is what also gives people, it makes you different. Because you're really being honest in what you're giving. You know what I mean? There's a lot of songs, even when I'm in the studio I will choose a take even though my piano solo is better on this take, the vibe and the spirit and the honesty of this take is better and I'll choose that one. You know I don't like to take solos from here and put them over there. I'm not like that. Because now the bass isn't — and what I play, the bass player and the drummer are reacting to what I did. So if I move my solo over now it's sounding like they aren't with me. The gelling isn't that spiritual thing, really, the connection isn't there. But I'll take a solo that's not as good because the connection is there, and leave it.

Question: Where do you see music in the next ten years, from dealing with the whole fusion thing that we have going on now, and mixing in the whole like neo-soul, Gospel feel and everything. Where do you see it going?

RG: I don't know. Because there's two waves going on. There's one side, it's like what the hell are you doing in music? And then there's the other side whereas like that's awesome. And they're both doing this. And I don't know. I have no idea. I wish I knew the answer to that but I don't know. I hope people keep, like I said there's always waves of great organic music. And there's always bad music. Bad music never goes in waves. It's just there. It's like the good shit's wavy and the bad music's just there. So I'm hoping the good music will stop being as wavy. Or you know the good music's always been there, it's just not as accessible as other music. It's not in your face. Not as obvious. You've got to dig for it. Versus bad music, it's in your face. When you get in a cab it's going to be there. You know. You know you could sing a song that you hate because of that. Because they get so much marketing for these bad songs.

GT: Can you see yourself doing something with Beyoncé?

RG: Yeah. I do. I don't know when. It's funny, when Beyoncé first went solo I had just got out of college. I think it was 2000, 2001. And they were about to get her solo career happening. So she called me to be her music director. And it was right when neo-soul was happening. So when she went solo she was going to go neo-soul. You know. So we talked for a good three months getting together, I had the band together and we were

happening anymore." And then she went, that's when she went pop, totally pop. So they immediately switched that up. But I totally see at some point us doing something at some point. I don't know when but, one day.

GT: All right. I think it's time to go, we've got a show to see.

RG: All right.